# LinkedIn for Job Search: Get Recruiters to Find You (Mini Guide)

*Based on "LinkedIn for Personal Branding: The Ultimate Guide" by Sandra Long*

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**Your LinkedIn profile creates a first impression before anyone meets you in person. 65% of professionals say the impression you make online is just as important as the one you make in person.**

**This guide gives you Sandra Long's proven framework to stand out, to be the "orange fish" swimming in your own direction.**

## STEP 1: REACH ALL-STAR STATUS (Your Foundation)

Before anything else, hit LinkedIn's "All-Star" profile strength. This is the minimum threshold that makes your profile more visible in search results.

**All-Star requires:**

- Professional photo
- 50+ connections
- Current position listed
- 2 past positions
- Education
- 3+ skills
- Industry and location filled in

**Why it matters:** All-Star profiles are significantly more likely to appear in search results. Think of it as the entry ticket — you won't get found without it.

⬜ **Action: Check your profile strength indicator. Fill any gaps listed above this weekend.**

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## STEP 2: WRITE A STRATEGIC HEADLINE (220 Characters)

Your headline and photo are often the only things someone sees before deciding whether to click on your profile. Most people leave the default — their job title. That's a missed opportunity.

**Sandra's Top Headline Tips:**

- **Use keywords** — the words in your headline help people find you in search
- **Add a value statement** — don't just say what you are, say what you do for people
- **Be specific** — "Account Executive" is generic; add what makes you different
- **Keep your corporate brand** if it's recognizable — "Senior VP at GE" draws clicks
- **Look at others** in your industry for ideas and language

**Before & After Examples (from the book):**

❌ Marketing Manager

✅ Marketing Executive | Growth Strategy | Channel Development | Partner Relations

❌ Human Resources Consultant

✅ HR Consultant | Talent Acquisition | Employee Retention | Optimizing Your Workforce for Growth

❌ Operations Manager

✅ Operations Manager | Call Center Optimization | Black Belt | Six Sigma | Military Veteran

❌ CFO

✅ CFO | Chief Financial Officer | Delivering Profitable Growth Strategies

❌ Unemployed Seeking Marketing Role

✅ Marketing Leader | Digital Media | Lead Generation Specialist | Military Veteran | Helping Organizations Grow

**3 "Value-Focused" Phrases You Can Add (from the book):**

- "I help people and businesses develop positive communication skills"
- "Making entrepreneurship available to all women"
- "Protecting family assets and wealth"

⬜ **Action: Write 3-5 headline options. Pick the one that's most compelling AND includes your strategic keywords.**

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# STEP 3: CRAFT YOUR ABOUT SECTION (2,600 Characters)

Your About section is valuable digital real estate. Don't just rehash what's already in your profile. Weave together your story in a way that compels people to want to work with you or refer you.

### Sandra's 10 Tips for a Great About Section:

1. **Focus** — Craft an excellent introduction. Write it in Word first for spelling and grammar.
2. **Set goals** — What are you trying to achieve? New clients? A new job? Speaking invitations?
3. **Consider your readers** — Think about ALL your audiences. What makes them want to contact you?
4. **Use the space** — LinkedIn says essays of at least 40 words make your profile more likely to be found in search. Most strong profiles include 2-3 paragraphs.
5. **Be real and genuine** — Let the real "you" come through. Include personal interests.
6. **Write in first person** — Creates warmth. 40% of recruiters look for personality in profiles.
7. **Use strategic language** — Include keywords naturally. Add a specialties list at the end.
8. **Make it attractive** — Use spacing, capitalization, and symbols for visual appeal.
9. **Start with a hook** — Draw readers in. Make them want to click "see more."
10. **Close carefully** — End with a specialties list and contact info for a "quick read" option.

### Use the Five H's Format:

Sandra's signature structure for writing your About section:

🪝 **Hook** — Start with a compelling opening that makes people want to read more

🤝 **Help** — Describe how you help your clients, prospects, or employer

😊 **Human** — Add personality. Share what drew you to your work, your values, or your interests outside work

🔑 **Hot-Words** — Weave in your strategic keywords naturally throughout

👋 **Hello** — End with your contact information so people can reach you

### Choose Your Writing Persona:

Sandra identifies six approaches to writing your About section. Pick the one that fits you:

**The Historian** — Chronological story of your career. If you use this approach, make sure to add personality. Don't just repeat your Experience section.

**The Storyteller** — Open with a great story that connects to your personal brand. Sandra's favorite approach: "I just love stories."

**The Weaver** — Perfect if your career path isn't linear. Use the About section to connect the dots and explain why your varied experience makes sense together.

**The Themer** — Best for senior leaders or people with wide-ranging experience. Pick 3-4 themes that have carried through your career and organize around those.

**The Personality** — Let your character and working style take center stage. Show how you approach problems and collaborate.

**The Business Leader** — Write your About as a "preselling document" for prospective clients. Still use first person and tell your story.

⬜ **Action: Pick your persona. Write your About section using the Five H's structure. Draft it in a separate document first, then paste it in.**

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## STEP 4: BUILD SOCIAL PROOF (Recommendations & Endorsements)

Online reviews can make the difference in being found, hired, and trusted. People who have recommendations and endorsements on LinkedIn have worked at it — it doesn't happen by accident.

### Skills & Endorsements

- **Clean up your skills** — Remove anything that doesn't match your brand. Just because someone endorsed you for a skill doesn't mean it belongs on your profile.
- **Pin your top 3** — The first three skills shown on your profile should be your most strategic ones.
- **Review every few months** — Your skills list should evolve as your career does.

**LinkedIn Fun Fact:** Users with at least 5 relevant skills are messaged 31x more and viewed 17x more than those without.

### Sandra's 6-Step Recommendation Process:

1. **Make a list** — Decide who can describe your work firsthand from working directly with you
2. **Consider timing** — The best time to ask is right after finishing a project, leaving a job, or receiving a big compliment
3. **Ask personally** — For close contacts, a note works. For others, warm them up first — call or meet for coffee. Make a personalized request to dramatically increase your success rate
4. **Make it easy** — Ask if they'd like talking points or if you should draft something for them to edit
5. **Follow up gently** — People have good intentions but get busy. A gentle reminder is smart
6. **Show gratitude** — Send a thank-you note or LinkedIn message

**Goal:** Get at least 3 recommendations. Give at least 5. The best ones come from customers, your direct boss, or people with significant titles.

**Pro tip from the book:** It's perfectly OK to recommend someone who recommends you. After a great project: *"I really enjoyed working with you. Let's write a LinkedIn recommendation for each other based on this great achievement."*

⬜ **Action: Identify 3-5 people to ask for recommendations. Send your first request this week using the 6-step process.**

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# STEP 5: CREATE & ENGAGE WITH CONTENT (The 80/20 Rule)

Sandra's content rule is the single most important engagement strategy in the book.

### The 80/20 Rule:

**Spend at least 80% of your content time engaging with OTHER people's content.** Be helpful. Provide thought leadership. Share useful insights.

Avoid selling, asking for meetings, or asking for jobs. This helpful approach builds relationships and makes people come to YOU.

**Think of it like a networking event (Sandra's analogy):**

- ❌ Bill walks in and immediately spews his sales pitch. He never comes up for air. Everything revolves around himself. Bill repels.
- ✅ Mark enters and shows authentic interest in others. He engages with interesting conversation. Mark attracts.

The online world works exactly the same way.

### The Three C's of Content:

**Create** — Write original posts, articles, or record native video. Posts of 800-1,200 characters tend to perform well.

**Curate** — Find valuable content and share it with YOUR unique perspective. Add insightful commentary — don't just hit "repost."

**Comment** — Sandra's #1 secret. If she could do only ONE thing, it would be to comment daily with meaningful, insightful, or supportive notes.

### Commenting Best Practices (from the book):

- Write longer, insightful comments — not just "Great post!"
- Add white space if your comment is lengthy
- Comment back with an @-mention (tag)
- Avoid links unless absolutely necessary
- Never hijack someone's post to push your own agenda

### Build Relationships Through Comments:

**When you create a post:** You post → Someone comments → You like AND reply to their comment (with @-mention) → Visit their profile and engage with their content → Invite them to connect with a personal note → Continue being helpful → Watch relationships develop organically

**When you engage with others:** Find interesting content in a hashtag stream → Leave an insightful comment with @-mention → They comment back and check your profile → Like their reply → Visit their profile, comment on another post → Let it lead to a natural connection

### Content Types Available on LinkedIn:

- **Posts** (800-1,200 characters, appear in home feed)
- **Native video** (upload from phone, add captions)
- **Live video** (broadcast from personal or company page)
- **Document posts** (upload PDFs or PowerPoints)
- **Polls** (great for driving engagement and conversation)
- **Articles** (long-form blog content, 1,500-3,000 words)

⬜ **Action: This week, comment on 5 posts per day with genuine, thoughtful insights. Share 1 curated article with your own perspective added.**

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## STEP 6: OPTIMIZE FOR SEARCH & VISIBILITY

Being found on LinkedIn requires intentional keyword placement and profile completeness.

### Where to Place Keywords:

- Headline (highest search weight)
- About section (especially the specialties list)
- Experience section titles and descriptions
- Skills section
- Publications, projects, and other sections

### Quick Visibility Wins:

- **Custom URL** — Change your LinkedIn URL to linkedin.com/in/yourname
- **Public profile** — Make sure your profile is visible on Google
- **Location & industry** — Fill these in correctly; they affect search results
- **Featured section** — Showcase your best content, media mentions, case studies, or lead magnets at the top of your profile
- **Rich media** — Add videos, presentations, and documents to your Experience sections

### Professional Photo Guidelines:

- Professional, recent, high-quality
- You are the only person in the photo
- Friendly expression
- Minimum 400 × 400 pixels

### Background Banner:

- 1584 × 396 pixels
- Use it to reinforce your brand (tagline, visual, website)

⬜ **Action: Customize your URL. Add a background banner. Upload 1-2 rich media items to your Experience sections.**

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## YOUR 4-WEEK ACTION PLAN

### Week 1: Foundation

- [ ] Check your All-Star status on LinkedIn — fill any gaps
- [ ] Update photo and background banner
- [ ] Rewrite headline (write 3-5 options, pick the best)
- [ ] Choose your About section persona

### Week 2: Power Sections

- [ ] Write About section using the Five H's format
- [ ] Update top 3 Experience entries with accomplishments (not responsibilities)
- [ ] Clean up Skills — remove irrelevant ones, pin your top 3

- [ ] Add Featured section content (3-6 items)

### Week 3: Social Proof

- [ ] Send 3-5 recommendation requests using the 6-step process
- [ ] Write 2-3 recommendations for others
- [ ] Give authentic endorsements to colleagues
- [ ] Customize your LinkedIn URL

### Week 4: Content & Engagement

- [ ] Apply the 80/20 rule — comment on 5+ posts daily
- [ ] Share 2-3 posts this week (create or curate with your perspective)
- [ ] Use the relationship-building comment strategy
- [ ] Review your profile analytics — what's working?

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## KEY BOOK PRINCIPLES TO REMEMBER

🐟 **Be the Orange Fish** — Most people on LinkedIn look the same. Your unique personal brand is what makes people want to connect, hire, or buy from you. Don't blend in with the blue fish.

🎭 **Demonstrate, Don't Tell** — Don't say you have "demonstrated leadership." Actually demonstrate it through your stories, accomplishments, and content. Show, don't claim.

✍️ **First Person Always** — Write your About section in first person. It creates warmth and connection. Third person feels cold and impersonal.

💬 **Commenting Is King** — If you can only do one thing on LinkedIn, comment daily with meaningful insights. It builds more relationships than posting alone.

🤝 **80/20 Everything** — 80% helping others, 20% about you. This applies to content, engagement, and networking.

📊 **Keep at least 80% of your content informational** — and no more than 20% promotional. People will tune you out if every post is a sales pitch.

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## QUICK REFERENCE: CHARACTER COUNTS

| Section | Character Limit |
|---|---|

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|---|---|
| Headline | 220 characters |
| About | 2,600 characters |
| Experience (each) | 2,000 characters |
| Skills | Up to 50 skills |
| Photo | Min 400 × 400 px |
| Banner | 1584 × 396 px |

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**This mini guide is based on *LinkedIn for Personal Branding: The Ultimate Guide* by Sandra Long. For the complete framework with additional examples, case studies, and advanced strategies, get the full book.**